Scientists Find the 'Chunkiest' Ancient Squid Relative

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Two rare **fossils** from Wyoming show a new kind of ancient sea animal. It lived about 160 million years ago, in the **Jurassic Period**.

The animal is named Wyoteuthis linsterorum. It was a **belemnite**, a relative of today's squid and octopuses. **Belemnites** had a hard, bullet-shaped part inside their bodies called a **rostrum**. That part often turns into a fossil.

Most **belemnite fossils** in Wyoming are thin, only 1 to 2 centimeters wide. People there call them squid butts! The new one is about 6 centimeters wide, making it the thickest **belemnite** ever found. The whole animal may have been about two feet long.

The first fossil was found in the late 1990s and sat in a museum drawer for years. A second one was given to the Wyoming Dinosaur Center in 2019. Scientists used **CT scans** to look inside the **fossils**. Researcher Alexey Ippolitov thinks its big size may have helped it hunt smaller **belemnites**.

Word Treasure

fossils -- Remains or traces of living things from long ago, saved in rock.

Jurassic Period -- A time in Earth's history millions of years ago.

belemnite -- An ancient sea animal related to squid that no longer lives today.

rostrum -- The hard, bullet-shaped part inside a belemnite's body.

CT scans -- Special X-ray pictures that show the inside of something.

Background you need

Fossils help scientists learn about animals that lived long ago.

Belemnites were sea animals related to squid, and their hard inner parts are often found as fossils.

Long ago, a sea covered part of what is now Wyoming.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists, including researcher Alexey Ippolitov
WHAT: A new kind of ancient squid relative, the chunkiest belemnite ever found
WHERE: Wyoming
WHY: Two rare fossils let scientists compare and describe it

Why it matters

It shows that even very common fossils can still hold big surprises for curious kids and scientists.

Test what you remember

1. Where were the fossils found?

- (A) New Zealand
- (B) Wyoming
- (C) Florida
- (D) Japan

2. Which animals are belemnites related to?

- (A) Frogs
- (B) Birds
- (C) Cats and dogs
- (D) Squid and octopuses

3. What do people in Wyoming call belemnite fossils?

- (A) Rock bullets
- (B) Sea stars
- (C) Squid butts
- (D) Dino teeth

4. How wide is the new one?

- (A) About 60 centimeters
- (B) About 1 centimeter
- (C) About 2 feet
- (D) About 6 centimeters

5. How did scientists look inside the fossils?

- (A) By breaking them
- (B) With a magnifying glass only
- (C) With CT scans
- (D) By melting them

6. What may its big size have helped it do?

- (A) Hide in trees
- (B) Hunt smaller belemnites
- (C) Live on land
- (D) Fly

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Researcher Alexey Ippolitov: Thinks its big size may have helped it hunt smaller belemnites.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):